

The simple file organisation system for small businesses.

A practical guide to folders, naming conventions, and finding any document in under two minutes.

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Why this matters

Most small businesses do not have a file organisation problem. They have a file chaos problem. Documents saved in a hurry, named whatever came to mind, stored wherever was convenient. Over time this becomes a system that only the person who created it can navigate.

This guide gives you a simple, practical folder structure and naming convention you can set up in an afternoon. Once in place, anyone in your team can find any document in under two minutes, including someone who has never seen the system before.

THE TWO-MINUTE TEST

Before you set this up, run this test. Ask yourself or a team member to find these three documents right now:

- 1 Your most recent staff training record for any team member.
- 2 Your current public liability or professional indemnity insurance certificate.
- 3 The last complaint or feedback you received and how it was resolved.

If it took more than two minutes

Your filing system needs attention. The good news is that fixing it takes one afternoon, not a week. This guide shows you how.

THE RECOMMENDED FOLDER STRUCTURE

This structure works for most small service businesses. Adapt the names to suit your sector but keep the logic the same. Everything has a home.

01 Staff Recruitment

↳ Individual's name

Evidence of all relevant recruitment checks

02 Staff Training

↳ Individual's name

↳ Year

Evidence of all relevant training certificates

03 Compliance and Safety

↳ Policies

All current policies

↳ Risk Assessments

↳ Year

↳ Audits

↳ Year

↳ Equipment Servicing

↳ Year

↳ Insurance

↳ Year

Certificates and renewals

04 Clients and Feedback

↳ Positive Feedback

↳ Year

↳ Month

↳ Complaints

↳ Year

↳ Month

05 Finance

↳ Invoices Sent

↳ Year

↳ Month

↳ Expenses

↳ Year

↳ Month

↳ Payroll

↳ Year

↳ Month

↳ Supplier Contracts

Organised by supplier name

06 Operations

↳ Templates

Forms and checklists

↳ Meetings

↳ Year

↳ Month

↳ Procedures

How-to guides

THE NAMING CONVENTION

A naming convention is a simple rule that everyone follows when saving a file. Without one, the same document gets saved as 'John contract', 'contract john', 'Johns employment contract final v2' and 'FINAL FINAL john'. With one, it is always the same format and always findable.

The rule

[YYYYMMDD] [Document type] [Name or reference]

BEFORE — hard to find	AFTER — easy to find
<i>john contract</i>	20250315 Contract John Smith
<i>risk assessment fire FINAL</i>	20250601 Risk Assessment Fire Safety
<i>training cert mandy</i>	20250910 Training Certificate Mandy Jones First Aid
<i>invoice april</i>	20250430 Invoice 0042 ABC Company
<i>complaint email</i>	20251105 Complaint Log Reception Delay Resolved

THREE RULES THAT MAKE THE SYSTEM WORK

Rule 1 — File at the point of creation

Save the document in the right folder with the right name the moment you create or receive it. Never save it to the desktop to sort later. Later never comes and desktops are not always backed-up.

Rule 2 — One version, one location

Never keep multiple copies of the same document in different folders. When a document is updated, replace it in its original location and update the date in the filename. Archive the old version.

Rule 3 — Write it down and share it

The naming convention only works if everyone uses it. Write it on one page, share it with the team, and put a copy in the 06 Operations folder. New starters read it on day one.

MAKING SEARCH WORK FOR YOU

Once your files are named consistently, search becomes your most powerful tool. On a Mac use Spotlight (Cmd+Space). On Windows use File Explorer search. On Google Drive or OneDrive use the search bar at the top.

If you have followed the naming convention, searching '2024 Risk Assessment' will immediately surface all risk assessments from 2024. Searching 'John Smith' will find every document related to that person across all folders.

SETTING IT UP — YOUR ONE-AFTERNOON CHECKLIST

Work through this in one session

- ☐ Create the six main folders on your drive or cloud storage
- ☐ Create the subfolders inside each one
- ☐ Write your naming convention on one page and save it in 06 Operations
- ☐ Migrate your existing documents into the right folders with correct names
- ☐ Delete duplicates and anything that no longer needs to exist
- ☐ Share the naming convention with your team
- ☐ Run the two-minute test again to confirm it works

This is just the start.

Good file organisation is the foundation of an operationally sound business. Once your documents have a home, everything else becomes easier; audits, inspections, staff handovers, and the everyday task of running the business without chaos.

If you want to go further, Ordena works with small businesses to build practical operational systems across all seven of the area's most businesses have not sorted.

The FREE operational health check at ordena.co.uk takes five minutes and shows you exactly where your gaps are.

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